

Falcons and caracaras

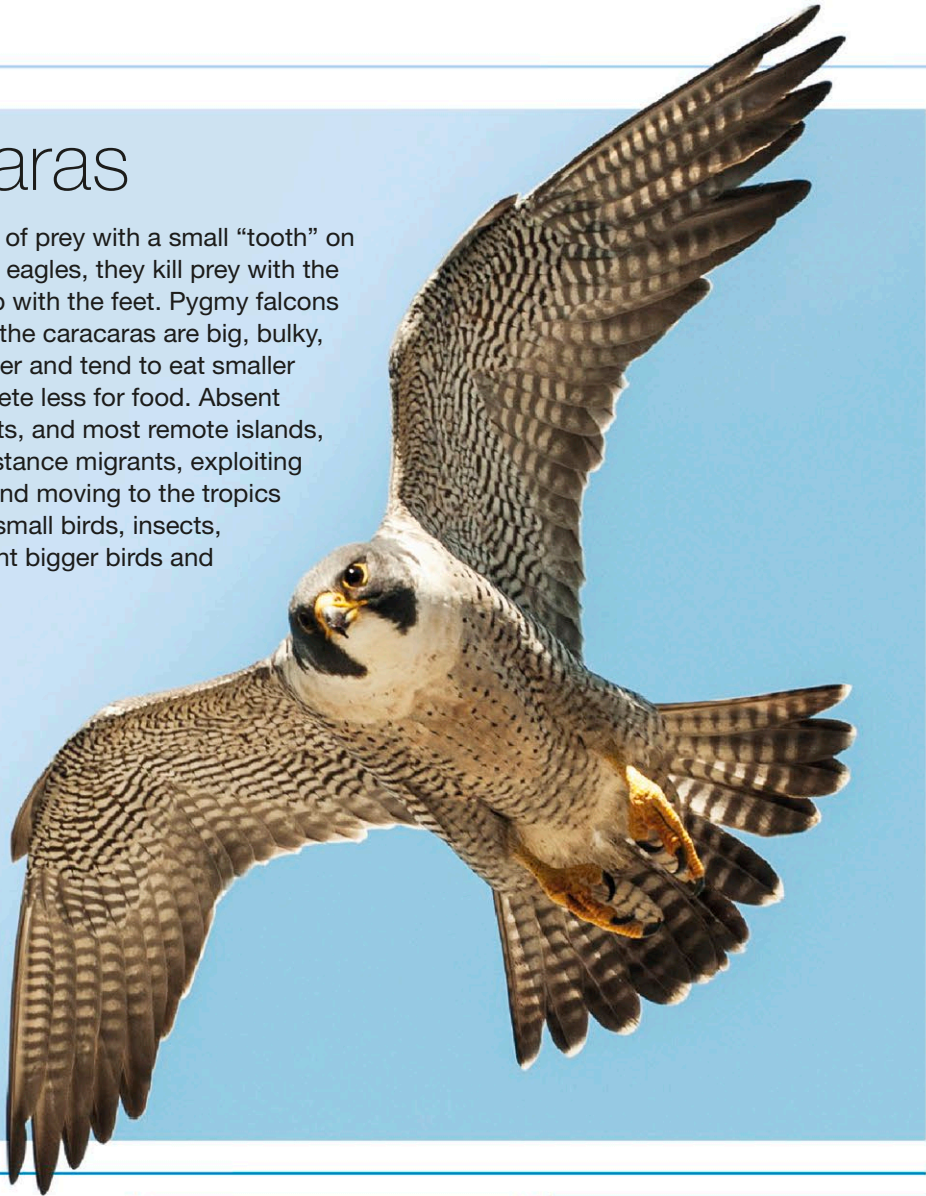
PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Falconiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	66

Falcons are dark-eyed, diurnal birds of prey with a small “tooth” on the bill; unlike hawks, buzzards, and eagles, they kill prey with the bill rather than the claws or tight grip with the feet. Pygmy falcons are tiny, but gyrfalcons, sakers, and the caracaras are big, bulky, heavy-bodied birds. Males are smaller and tend to eat smaller prey than females, so the pair compete less for food. Absent only from polar areas, densest forests, and most remote islands, falcons are found almost worldwide. Some are long-distance migrants, exploiting food sources in cold or temperate regions in summer and moving to the tropics outside the breeding season. Smaller species feed on small birds, insects, and rodents; larger ones, such as the prairie falcon, hunt bigger birds and mammals. Caracaras are versatile scavengers.

Reproduction

Caracaras build bulky nests and falcons use abandoned nests of another species, or lay eggs on a bare ledge or in an unlined tree cavity. Red-footed falcons are colonial and use nests of rooks, while pygmy falcons use the nests of African weavers. Both parents incubate eggs and care for the young; often highly secretive in the early stages, pairs may be noisy and obvious if nests with large chicks or newly fledged young are approached. Falcons are susceptible to insecticide poisoning, but some have recovered after catastrophic population declines in the 1960s.

PEREGRINE FALCON
A short “thumb” and tapered tips to the outer wing feathers allow falcons to control their wing shape and airflow over its surface.



Caracara plancus

Southern crested caracara



Location South America

Length 19½–23 in (49–59 cm)
Weight 1¾–3¼ lb (0.85–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



black cap
white cheek
bare legs

One of 2 similar American crested caracaras, this striking bird of prey has a cream head and breast; black cap; and bare, orange face. It reveals large pale patches in the wings and tail when it flies. Its outstretched head; straight, flat wings; and narrow tail give a distinctive cross shape in the air. It occupies open country with scattered trees, often close to people. Although related to falcons, it looks buzzard-shaped yet behaves like a vulture. It has long legs and spends much time walking on the ground, where it takes whatever food it can find, catch, or steal from other birds, including black and turkey vultures, which it dominates at carcasses. It eats anything from dead animals, young chicks, frogs, snakes, and freshwater turtles to rotting vegetables, fish, worms, and insects, but is rarely able to catch fit, mobile prey. Pairs build large nests of sticks and grass in trees, which become soiled with uneaten food.

Micrastur ruficollis

Barred forest falcon

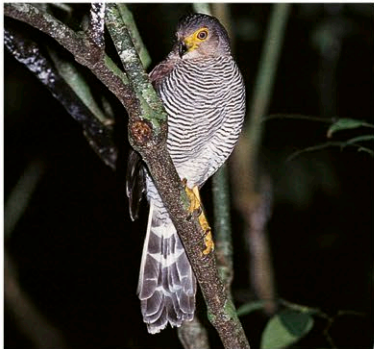


Location S. Mexico to N. South America

Length 13–15 in (33–38 cm)
Weight 5–8 oz (150–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Compared to other falcons, forest falcons have relatively short, rounded wings—a shape that helps them maneuver as they hunt among trees. This species has long and slender legs, with small feet and sharp talons. It hunts from trees, with short dashes out to seize lizards, and also catches army ants on the ground.



Falco punctatus

Mauritius kestrel



Location Mauritius

Length 8–10 in (20–26 cm)
Weight 6–8 oz (175–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Endangered



This chestnut-brown, cream-fronted bird nearly became extinct because of destruction of its natural habitat of evergreen primary forest, but is now being raised in zoos and encouraged to inhabit secondary forest and scrub. In the 1970s, there were thought to be only 4–8 birds left, but, due to a successful breeding program, there are nearly 1,000.



white underparts with dark spots